3

1887, Chenab Colony

Few people in India today, familiar with Punjab's acclaim as the 'bread-basket' of India, recall the long road to its prosperity taken during those colonial days. Few remember how its modern lineage is traceable to the Canal Colonies of West Punjab during the heady days of the Raj. Fewer still can remember 1887, when the Chenab Colony was created by the Punjab government. This move diverted the waters of the River Chenab into a series of permanent canals and dramatically transformed what was a dry barren wasteland into a spectacularly fertile land, ripe for farming. [1] It is what made the Chenab Colony a model of success as a system of paternalistic administration. It created higher standards of living [2] by implementing carefully crafted methods of sanitation, economic planning and governmental bipartisanship. Yet, the colonial rulers of the Raj were not content to stop there. The model had to be emulated throughout the province. In this way, British colonial policy managed to privilege Punjab's agrarian development over its industrial growth. Security measures after the 1857 rebellion, during which Punjab played a strategic role, were aimed at keeping Punjabi farmers happy. It is worth recalling once again how the waters of the five rivers of the region were harnessed under the Canal Colonies project in an ambitious irrigation development project in such a way that the astonishing transformation of six million acres of desert into one of the richest agricultural regions of the whole of Asia became not just 'a stupendous engineering feat' but also 'the Colonial State's greatest achievement'. In this way, 'nowhere were the ideals of the modern rational state better epitomised than in the neatly laid squares of land in the canal colony villages'. [3] This is also when the eight bazaars of the new market